

NAME OF THE TERROR

No amount of political correctness can deny the new martyrdom chic its Islamist tag

■ By S. Prasannarajan

So welcome to Bangalore, the silicon shrine of the so-called flat world. Does it sound so yesterday? There is a shift—and Inshallah, we hope it's a temporary one—in perception after its migration from business pages to front pages. Bangalore has become the back story of Glasgow, and in a flat world, this transformation is perfectly in order. Globalisation, after all, is about the free passage of ideas, and one revolutionary idea that propels the

new martyrdom chic owes its origin to a misreading of the fastest growing religion of the day. It is hardly shocking when we get more of the Bangalore connection in the world wide web of Islamist terror. The way things are going—or the way those guys are driving their loaded SUVs into airport terminals—it may soon sound as banal as Bogotá connection or Belfast connection, Bali connection or Bradford connection. In a flat world, the drive to paradise is smooth and fast.

What is required in a moment like this is a display of granite national resolution—no finger-wagging demagoguery or no we-shall-slay-the-evil rage, please. Be just Gordon Brown. The London commentariat, with some hardcore conservative exceptions, is going gaga over how the new prime minister has passed the “bomb test”. Neither sentimental nor jingoistic, his words in the aftermath of the London bomb scare were described as reassuring and matter-of-fact. We Indians, though, are more emotionally demonstrative; call us mawkish, we don't care, pass the handkerchief please. In the wake of Glasgow, our prime minister could not have been more humane. “I could not sleep after watching the families of the Indians on TV last night. Labelling Indians as terrorists or Pakistanis as terrorists is best avoided. Terrorists are terrorists. They don't belong to any community or religion...” He was in conversation

with the women journalists of Delhi. Why did the prime ministerial heart bleed so profusely? Was it the company, or the power of television? Or is it that he is such a gentleman who understands the trauma of being “labelled”?

Maybe he doesn't watch too much Baghdad or other horrors; maybe, being a rare humanist, he alone realises who the real victim is. What is scary is that too much human-interest television may expose him to the magnitude of suffering in this world without compassion—and he may find solace in renunciation. The second part of his quote, though, is more politically immediate; it reflects a mindset familiar in Delhi and elsewhere, even in London, Al Qaeda's new Jihadistan.

“Terrorists are terrorists... they don't belong to any community or religion.” This is absolute bunkum, and we hear it from not only the Indian prime minister. Even

British Conservative leader David Cameron won't call it Islamist terror. In his “sombre” response, Brown, too, didn't say the I-word. Suddenly, there is a war on nomenclature. Any jihadist worth his Book and bomb will be profoundly offended by this condescending, hurt-them-not political correctness. Hurting whom? It is a false assumption that when you use the term Islamist terror, you are by implication stereotyping an entire community. You are not. You are not saying that the entire Muslim population subscribes to the sanguineous fantasies of Syed Qutb or Hasan al-Banna, Osama bin Laden or Ayman al-Zawahiri. But the bombers of London and elsewhere have a religion—and that alone defines them. An ex-jihadist like Ed Husain has even written a confessional bestseller on this, *The Islamist*.

Unlike those platitudinous politicians subordinated to votebanks, some influential Muslim community groups like the Muslim Council of Britain are realising that silence might be misinterpreted as solidarity. That is not enough. Audible dissent from within the community alone can redeem

Islam from the nihilistic ideology of Islamism, which, like any other ism, is sustained by the “enemy”.

In India, the use of the I-word in the context of terror is an official taboo: it is a negation of the secular. We may be one of the oldest—and the most stoic—victim states; we are a nation in denial. Today, Britain is paying the price for bleeding-heart multiculturalism, and it is coming to terms with the frightening reality that many of those British passport holders are the warrior citizens of a borderless Caliphate. We have been there before, long before. Being Indians, we are not going to lose sleep over that. ■



Illustration by SAURABH SINGH